

ABILIK // MADINAH ARABIC READING COURSE

QURANIC ARABIC READING, 1 TO 14



From the 28 letters to how the Shaddah works. A printer-friendly teaching guide following the Madinah Arabic Reading Course, lessons 1 through 14.

2026-06-21 · for the students

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COURSE MAP

We climb in three flights. First the letters, then the marks that give them sound (the harakat and the long vowels), then the special marks that finish a word, the Sukoon and the Shaddah. Take one lesson at a time, read every line out loud.

14 LESSONS	28 LETTERS	6 VOWEL MARKS	3 TANWIN
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WHAT WE COVER

The full path. Tick each lesson once you can read its examples without help.

NO	LESSON	WHAT IT TEACHES	STATUS
1	The Arabic Alphabet	The 28 letters and how their shapes change	TODO
2	Short Vowel, Fathah	The short 'a' mark above a letter	TODO
3	Short Vowel, Kasrah	The short 'i' mark below a letter	TODO
4	Short Vowel, Dammah	The short 'u' mark above a letter	TODO
5	Short Vowel Practice	Listening exercise on the three short vowels	TODO
6	Long Vowel, Alif al-Madd	Stretching 'a' into 'aa'	TODO
7	Long Vowel, Yaa al-Madd	Stretching 'i' into 'ee'	TODO
8	Long Vowel, Waaw al-Madd	Stretching 'u' into 'oo'	TODO
9	Long Vowel Practice	Telling short and long vowels apart	TODO
10	Tanwin, Fathatain	The 'an' ending	TODO
11	Tanwin, Kasratain	The 'in' ending	TODO
12	Tanwin, Dammatain	The 'un' ending	TODO
13	Tanwin Practice	Exercise on all three tanwin	TODO
14	Sukoon and Shaddah	The resting mark and the doubling mark	TODO

THE ARABIC ALPHABET

Arabic has 28 letters and is read from RIGHT to LEFT. Each letter has a name and a sound. Sad, Daad, Taa', Zaa' are heavy letters, read with a full mouth. Say each one out loud with your abi.

ا ALIF carrier, long 'aa'	ب BAA b as in book	ت TAA t as in top	ث THAA th as in think
ج JEEM j as in jam	ح HAA deep h from the throat	خ KHAA kh, raspy from the throat	د DAAL d as in door
ذ DHAAL th as in this	ر RAA rolled r	ز ZAAY z as in zoo	س SEEN s as in see
ش SHEEN sh as in ship	ص SAAD heavy s, full mouth	ض DAAD heavy d, full mouth	ط TAA' heavy t, full mouth
ظ ZAA' heavy th, full mouth	ع 'AYN deep a from the throat	غ GHAYN gh, like a gargle	ف FAA f as in fan
ق QAAF deep k from the back	ك KAAF k as in key	ل LAAM l as in love	م MEEM m as in moon
ن NOON n as in noon	و WAAW w, long 'oo'	ه HAA soft h as in hat	ي YAA y, long 'ee'

HOW THE SHAPES CHANGE

A letter looks a little different depending on where it sits in the word, at the start, in the middle, or at the end. The core shape stays, it just gains a tail or a joining line.

LETTER	ALONE	START	MIDDLE	END
Baa	ب	بـ	بـ	بـ
Seen	س	سـ	سـ	سـ
'Ayn	ع	عـ	عـ	عـ
Kaaf	ك	كـ	كـ	كـ
Meem	م	مـ	مـ	مـ
Haa	هـ	هـ	هـ	هـ

THE 6 LETTERS THAT NEVER JOIN TO THE LEFT

ا	د	ذ	ر	ز	و
Alif	Daal	Dhaal	Raa	Zaay	Waaw

These six join to the letter on their right, but the next letter always starts fresh after them.

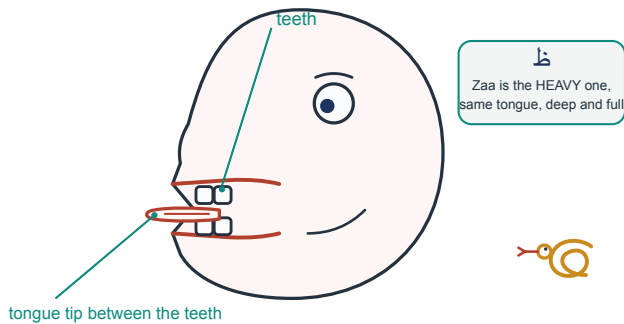
TONGUE POSITION, THE TRICKY LETTERS

A few letters do not have an English twin, so we learn them by where the tongue goes. Watch your abi, copy the mouth, feel the place. Snake letters put the tongue between the teeth, throat letters come from deep, and the two K letters move the tongue front to back.

The Snake Method

Thaa and Dhaal, the soft TH sound

ث ذ

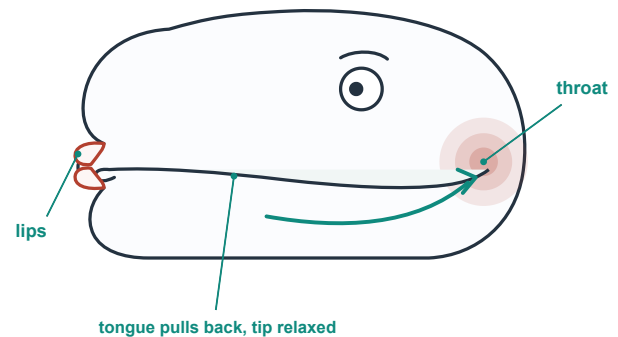


Stick your tongue out like a snake, th as in THINK

Throat letters

bogazdan gelen ses

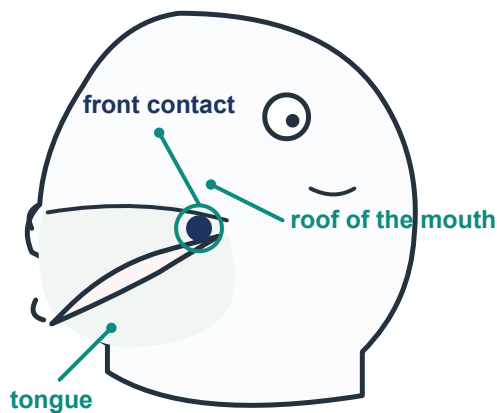
ح ع خ غ



no easy English match, feel it deep in the throat

the two K letters

ك ق

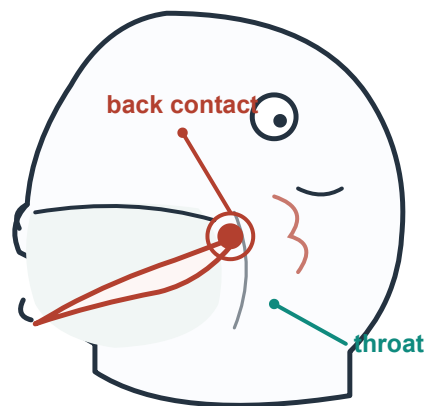


ك

Kaaf, front k

light, like KEY

same k, the contact point moves from front to far back



ق

Qaaf, deep k

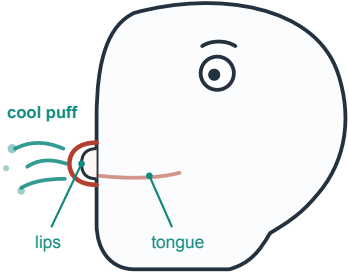
heavy, from the back

THE TWO H LETTERS AND THE THROAT PAIR

He is light and Ha is warm, learn them as a pair. Ayn and Gayn both live in the throat, Gayn is the gargle. Watch the faces, copy the breath.

two friendly H sounds

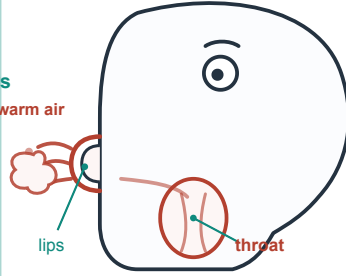
He ه



light h, from the mouth

He ه, light h, like Michael Jackson, hee hee

Ha ح



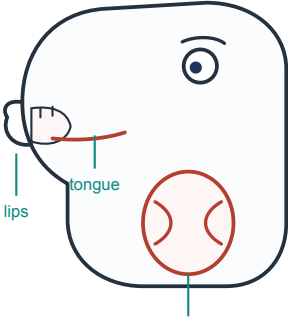
warm h, from the throat

Ha ح, warm throat h, like an oven, Ha from Habibullah

vs

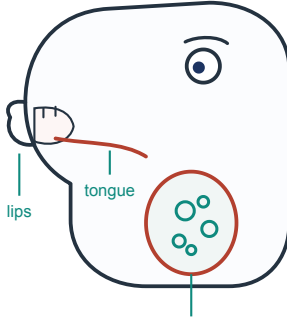
'Ayn ع vs Ghayn غ

both live in the throat, Ghayn is the gargle



'Ayn ع, deep voiced throat sound

tip, Ghayn is just gargling water at the back of your throat, like a French r



Ghayn غ, the gargle, gg method

SOUND REMINDERS

Little tricks to remember the hard sounds. Say each one out loud with your abi until it sticks.

و

VAV, WAW

Say it like WOW. It is a W, not a V.

ن

NUN, NOON

Say it like 12 o'clock NOON.

ه

HE, LIGHT H

The light, cool h. Michael Jackson, hee hee hee.

ح

HA, WARM H

The warm throat h. You are an oven making hot food.
Ha from Habibullah.

ش

SHEEN, SH

Sh, like your SHIN, the front of your leg.

ص خ ط

GUT PUNCH

Sad, Dad, Ti. The heavy full mouth letters, like the
oof of a gut punch.

ظ

ZI, DEEP Z

A deep heavy zee. Tongue between the teeth, push
from the bottom.

ع غ

THROAT, GG

Ayn and Gayn live in the throat. Gayn is the gargle,
the gg.

ث ذ

SNAKE TH

The soft th. Stick your tongue between your teeth like
a snake.

ك ق

KEF VS KAF

Kef is a light front k like KEY. Kaf is a heavy k from the
back.

THE LETTER FAMILY, RA ZE DAL ZEL

Four letters look almost the same. The dot on top is the head, that one is the husband. No dot is the wife. The round couple dips below the line, the straight couple sits on the line. Find the dot first, then check the shape.

The Letter Family ر ذ د ذ

Ra and Zay and Dal and Dhal, the four look alike

Couple One, the round family

curved shape that dips below the line



Zay, husband

honest z man

Ra, wife

no dot, no head

same round shape, both dip below the line

Couple Two, the straight family

angular shape that sits on the line



Dhal, husband

snake man, soft th

Dal, wife

no dot, no head

same straight shape, both sit on the line

Reading tip, how to tell them apart

1. First look for the dot, the dot is the head, that means the husband, and a z kind of sound.
2. Then look at the shape of the body.

Round and dipping below the line is the Ra and Zay couple.

Straight and sitting on the line is the Dal and Dhal couple.

SHORT VOWELS, THE HARAKAT

A bare letter has no sound yet. A small mark, a harakah, gives it a vowel. Three short vowels do most of the work. Try the same letter Baa with all three.



Fathah
short a

A small stroke ABOVE the letter. Gives a short 'a'. بَ is read 'ba'.



Kasrah
short i

A small stroke BELOW the letter. Gives a short 'i'. بِ is read 'bi'.



Dammah
short u

A small loop ABOVE the letter. Gives a short 'u'. بُ is read 'bu'.

Above means the sound rides on top, below means it sits underneath. Fathah and Dammah go above, Kasrah goes below.

SHORT VOWEL PRACTICE

WRITE 5 LETTERS WITH FATHAH, KASRAH, DAMMAH 1 – WRITE HERE

WRITE 5 LETTERS WITH FATHAH, KASRAH, DAMMAH 2 – WRITE HERE

WRITE 5 LETTERS WITH FATHAH, KASRAH, DAMMAH 3 – WRITE HERE

LONG VOWELS, THE MADD

A madd letter holds the vowel longer, about two beats instead of one. Each short vowel has a partner that stretches it. Alif stretches 'a', Yaa stretches 'i', Waaw stretches 'u'.

	Alif al-Madd long aa	Fathah then Alif. Stretches 'a' into 'aa'. با is read 'baa'.
	Yaa al-Madd long ee	Kasrah then Yaa. Stretches 'i' into 'ee'. بي is read 'bee'.
	Waaw al-Madd long oo	Dammah then Waaw. Stretches 'u' into 'oo'. بو is read 'boo'.

SHORT VS LONG, HEAR THE DIFFERENCE

			
ba short a	baa long a	bi short i	bee long i

LONG VOWEL PRACTICE

MARK EACH WORD SHORT OR LONG WHEN YOUR ABI READS IT 1 – WRITE HERE

MARK EACH WORD SHORT OR LONG WHEN YOUR ABI READS IT 2 – WRITE HERE

MARK EACH WORD SHORT OR LONG WHEN YOUR ABI READS IT 3 – WRITE HERE

TANWIN, THE 'N' ENDING

Tanwin means writing a vowel mark TWICE. It adds an 'n' sound to the end of the word, with no extra letter. It only ever comes at the end of a word.



Fathatain

tanwin -an

Two fathah marks. Adds an 'n'. Sounds 'an'. Almost always written on an added Alif: اُنْ = 'ban'.



Kasratain

tanwin -in

Two kasrah marks below. Sounds 'in'. بِنْ = 'bin'.



Dammatain

tanwin -un

Two dammah marks above. Sounds 'un'. بُنْ = 'bun'.

A note on Fathatain, it is almost always written on a small Alif added at the end of the word, like كِتَابُنْ, read kitaaban.

TANWIN PRACTICE

READ 5 WORDS ENDING IN AN, IN, UN 1 – WRITE HERE

READ 5 WORDS ENDING IN AN, IN, UN 2 – WRITE HERE

THE SUKOOK, A RESTING LETTER

The Sukoon is a small circle above a letter. It says, this letter has NO vowel. You do not add a, i, or u. You just sound the letter and glide on. It is the letter resting.



Sukoon
no vowel

A small circle above the letter. It means NO vowel, the letter is a pure stop. You glide from the letter before it straight into the next.

READ THESE, THE SUKOOK LETTER IS THE STILL ONE

مِنْ

min
from

أَنْفٌ

anf
nose

بَيْتٌ

bayt
house

مَسْجِدٌ

masjid
mosque

In مِنْ the Noon rests, so you say mi then n, joined as min, not mina.

THE SHADDAH, A DOUBLED LETTER

This is where we are heading. The Shaddah is a small 'w' shaped mark above a letter. It means the letter is said TWICE, pressed and held. The trick, read the letter once as if it has a sukoon, then again with its vowel.



Shaddah
double it

A small 'w' shaped mark above the letter. It means the letter is DOUBLED. Press on it and hold a beat longer. Read the letter once with sukoon, then again with its vowel.

HOW TO READ A SHADDAH, STEP BY STEP

1. Find the letter under the shaddah.
 2. Say the letter once, closed and silent, like a sukoon.
 3. Say it again with the vowel that sits on the shaddah.
 4. The two presses blend into one strong, held sound.
- Example, رَبّ, the Baa is doubled, so it is rab then b, read rabb, not rab.

SHADDAH WORDS TO PRACTICE

دُبّ

dubb
bear

بَطّ

batt
duck

قِطّة

qittah
cat

رَبّ

rabb
Lord

THE SIX MARKS AT A GLANCE

Once you know these six marks plus the long vowels, you can sound out almost any word in the Quran.

اَ **Fathah**

SHORT A

One stroke above. Read 'ba'.

اِ **Kasrah**

SHORT I

One stroke below. Read 'bi'.

اُ **Dammah**

SHORT U

One loop above. Read 'bu'.

اَنْ **Tanwin**

ADDS N

Doubled mark at word end. Read 'ban, bin, bun'.

اَ **Sukoon**

NO VOWEL

A circle. The letter rests, no vowel.

اَ **Shaddah**

DOUBLE

A w mark. The letter is said twice, held.

READ THESE WORDS

Now put it together. Sound out each word slowly, letter then mark, then say the whole word. Your abi will tell you the meaning.

أَب

ab
father

أُمُّ

umm
mother

يَد

yad
hand

مَاء

maa
water

نَار

naar
fire

نُور

noor
light

قَمَر

qamar
moon

بَيْت

bayt
house

قَلْب

qalb
heart

كِتَاب

kitaab
book

رَبّ

rabb
Lord

سَلَام

salaam
peace

READ THESE NAMES

Read your friends' names in Arabic. Find the marks you learned, then read it slowly. Try writing your own name at the bottom.

NAME	ARABIC (WITH MARKS)	READ IT
Nihat	نِهَاد	Ni-haad
Cebraail	جِبْرَائِيل	Cib-raa-il
Habibullah	حَبِيبُ اللَّهِ	Ha-bii-bul-laah
Salih	صَالِح	Saa-lih

Tip, in Habibullah you can hear the Ha from the throat, the warm oven sound, and the shaddah doubling the Lam.

MY OWN NAME

STUDENT PRACTICE NOTES

WORD I READ TODAY, AND THE MARK I WORKED ON 1 – WRITE HERE

WORD I READ TODAY, AND THE MARK I WORKED ON 2 – WRITE HERE

WORD I READ TODAY, AND THE MARK I WORKED ON 3 – WRITE HERE

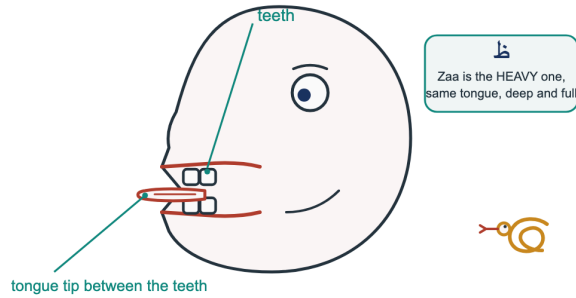
Tongue position and letter reminders, teacher reference

The diagrams used in this handout, all on one sheet for quick reference.

The Snake Method

Thaa and Dhaal, the soft TH sound

ث ذ

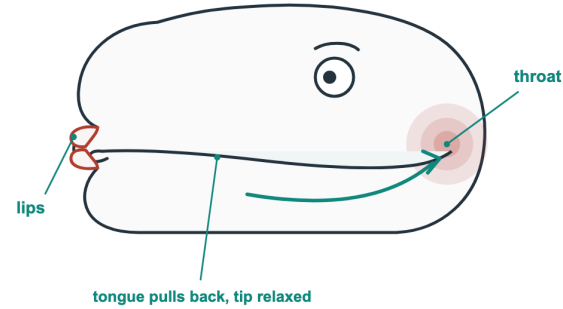


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Throat letters

bogazdan gelen ses

ح ع خ غ

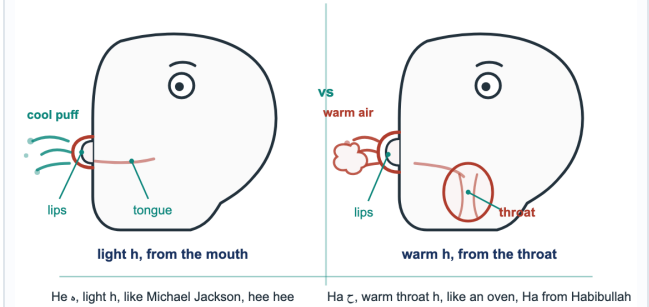


no easy English match, feel it deep in the throat

two friendly H sounds

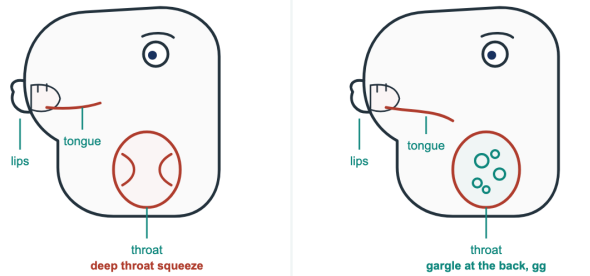
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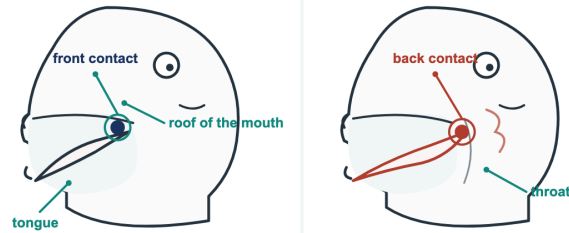
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Ghayn غ, the gargle, gg method

the two K letters

ك ق

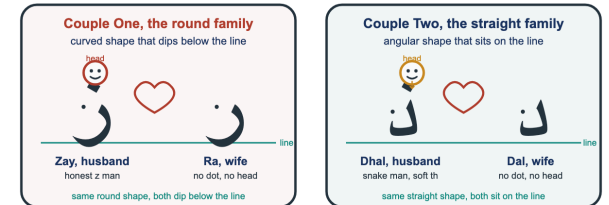


ك
Kaaf, front k
light, like KEY
same k, the contact point moves from front to far back

ق
Qaaf, deep k
heavy, from the back

The Letter Family ر ذ ن

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